

The Past Is Not The Person

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ABOUT THIS PIECE

The second column in a series on marriage examines what India's own scriptural traditions say about women, relationships, and redemption. Drawing from the Chandogya Upanishad, Valmiki Ramayana, and the Devi Bhagavata Purana, the piece argues that ancient wisdom offered grace — not permanent judgment. From Ahalya elevated by Ram as mahabhaga to Devi Tara welcomed back without punishment, the scriptures show a tradition that did not define a person by their past. The past is not the person — and our traditions always knew it.

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NH-33 black spots to get Rs 84 Cr facelift with underpasses and flyover

PNS : JAMSHEDPUR

In a major step towards improving road safety and easing traffic congestion on National Highway-33, the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) has approved the construction of two underpasses and one flyover at three major accident-prone stretches of the highway. The ambitious project, estimated to cost around 784 crore, aims to eliminate dangerous black spots and significantly reduce road accidents along the busy corridor connecting Jharkhand, West Bengal and Odisha.

The Union Ministry of Road Transport and Highways has granted formal approval for the project, following which NHAI signed an agreement with the executing agency for the commencement of construction work.

According to officials, the work order was issued to M/s SRC Mathura on May 21, 2026, and the agency has been directed to complete the project within 18 months. Senior NHAI officials will closely monitor the construction work on a daily basis to ensure quality standards and timely completion.



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The project will focus on three critical black spots located at Ghatshila, Baharagora and Chandil, which have witnessed repeated accidents over the years. At Phuldungri in Ghatshila, a 0.675-kilometre-long underpass will be constructed to facilitate safe movement of local residents heading towards the hospital and bus stand without crossing high-speed highway

traffic.

Similarly, a 1.33-kilometre underpass will come up at Baharagora Junction to ease traffic congestion and provide safer crossing facilities for villagers and commuters.

The third and most significant component of the project is a 1.85-kilometre-long flyover at Chandil Junction, located at the intersection of NH-33 and NH-32 (Ghodaleng-

Purulia Road). The flyover is expected to separate local traffic from highway movement, thereby reducing severe traffic jams and preventing accidents at the busy junction.

Police records indicate that the three black spots have become highly vulnerable zones for commuters. In the past three years alone, at least 12 people have lost their lives while 35 others sustained serious injuries in road accidents at these locations. The alarming rise in mishaps prompted demands for urgent structural intervention.

The project received momentum after Jamshedpur MP Bidyut Baran Mahato raised the issue before Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari, highlighting the hazardous condition of the highway stretches. Following the minister's directions, a Detailed Project Report (DPR) was prepared and subsequently approved.

Residents and daily commuters have welcomed the initiative, expressing hope that the long-awaited infrastructure upgrade will make NH-33 safer and more efficient for travelers across the region.

Six, including minor, held with brown sugar in Latehar

PNS : DALTONGANJ

Latehar police have intensified their crackdown against drug trafficking amid growing concerns over an expanding narcotics network in the district. In a major operation, police arrested six youths, including a minor, and recovered 5.73 grams of brown sugar packed in 29 sachets, locally called "puryas".

The operation was led by Latehar SDPO Sandip Kumar Gupta. Acting on information, the police team intercepted three motorcycles near Mougner Mode while

the accused were travelling from Richughutta to Latehar.

Police also seized 714,140 in cash and seven mobile phones from the accused. The identities of the five adult accused have been disclosed, while details of the minor have been withheld as per legal provisions.

The arrested accused have been identified as Sonu Singh alias Bhagat (20), Ritesh Singh (23), Chhatis Singh (22), Tabaseer Khan (19), and Faizan Khan (20). Three of them are residents of Ichak village under Jalim post office, while two are from Patratu village in Latehar district. The

five adults were sent to judicial custody, while the minor was sent to an observation home.

SDPO Gupta said police have placed Ichak Jalim and Patratu villages under surveillance to determine whether more youths are involved in drug peddling.

"Our drive against drug trafficking will become more intense. Latehar police will spare none involved in the illegal trade," Gupta said.

Notably, shortly after Gupta took charge as SDPO on May 21, Chandwa police seized 140 kg of marijuana near Tori railway crossing.

Retro to Metro Musical evening mesmerises Ranchi audience

PNS : RANCHI

A grand musical evening titled "Retro Se Metro, Tab Se Ab Tak - Music Ki Journey" captivated Bollywood music lovers at the prestigious IMA Ranchi Auditorium, offering the audience an unforgettable blend of nostalgia and contemporary melodies. The event was organised by Raj Kumar Pathak under the theme "Ek Shaam... Yaadein Purani, Ehsaas Naye".

The highlight of the evening was the soulful performance by Bollywood singer Rohan Dev Pathak, whose energetic and melodious renditions kept the audience engrossed till late in the night. He performed several popular Bollywood songs, including "Ye Reshmi Zulfein", "Aaj Mausam Bada Beimaan Hai", "Parda Hai Parda", "Aaj Se Meri Saari Galiyan Teri Ho Gayi", and "AchhaChalta Hoon, Duaon Mein Yaad Rakhna". The audience responded with loud applause and cheers throughout his performance.

Singer Sejal Jain also won hearts with her captivating stage presence and melodious voice. Her performances of "Jhumka Gira Re" and "Sasural Genda Phool" filled the auditorium with enthusiasm, leaving the audience swaying to the music. The



musical evening turned into a memorable celebration of Bollywood music, emotions, and timeless melodies for Ranchi's music enthusiasts.

The programme was attended by Justice Dr. S.N. Pathak as the chief guest. Several distinguished personalities and prominent citizens of the city also graced the occasion, including Dr. Kiran Singh, Dr. Bimlesh Singh, Deepak Ojha, Shobha Yadav, IAS officer Shashi Prakash Jha, former Jharkhand DGP Rajeev Kumar (IPS Retd.), Dr. Rajesh Balpan,

Dr. Suhas Tetevar, Lalit Ojha, Intkhab Ansari, Sanjay Mishra, Sanjay Ranjan (IPS Retd.), IAS officers Praveen Toppo, Manoj Tiwari and Suman Pathak, among others.

Expressing gratitude after the successful event, organiser Raj Kumar Pathak thanked the guests, artists, audience, and supporters. He said similar musical programmes would continue to be organised in Ranchi in the future to provide a vibrant platform for music lovers and entertainment enthusiasts in the city.

THE PAST IS NOT THE PERSON

Second in a series on marriage, tradition, and the lives we need to build together



BY NIVEDITA PANDEY

My previous column asked why Indian society treats staying in a damaging marriage as morally superior to leaving one. Recently, the former Miss Pune's case took a more troubling turn: beyond character assassination of the deceased woman by her in-laws, social media flooded with comments supporting that line of inquiry simply because she had relationships prior to marriage. This revealed a disturbing mindset: a woman's worth being still reduced to her relationship history.

People in India today are marrying later than ever. They study together, work together, form attachments, experience heartbreak, navigate loneliness, and make mistakes. This is human life, not a moral failure.

Yet the dominant conversation around marriage still evaluates people - particularly women - by whether they have a past, rather than the qualities that actually determine whether a household will be peaceful or destructive. Women are evaluated through the lens of sexual history and purity. Men are

evaluated through income and status. In both cases, a human being is reduced to a commodity while the inner qualities that sustain a marriage go unexamined.

Our traditions took a different view.

The Chandogya Upanishad tells the story of Satyakam Jabala, a boy who sought to learn Brahma Vidya from Sage Haridrumata Gautam. When asked about his lineage - the essential qualifier of that era - he returned to his mother, who shared that she had worked as a servant in many households and did not know who his father was. Rather than conceal this difficult truth, Satyakam repeated it to his teacher exactly as it was. The Sage accepted him immediately - recognising that a person who speaks an uncomfortable truth rather than a comforting lie has already demonstrated good character. Our sacred text was clear: birth and history do not determine worth. How you carry yourself today does.

The Valmiki Ramayana's Bal-Kand gives us Devi Ahilya - wife of Maharishi Gautam, cursed after an encounter with Indra. Some texts

portray her as deceived, others as having made a choice. What matters is the ending: Ram redeems and elevates her. Sage Vishwamitra introduces her to Ram not as a fallen woman but as mahabhaga - most noble and virtuous. She became one of the PanchKanyas - five women whose names are recited each morning to dispel sin. Nothing was treated as permanently broken. Redemption was always possible - enabled by Lord Ram himself.

The Devi Bhagavata Purana and Padma Purana give us Devi Tara, wife of Brihaspati - Guru of Gods. Tara, feeling neglected by a husband engrossed in divine duties, fell for Chandra and left to be with him. The Gods went to war over this before Brahma intervened - Devi Tara returned and Brihaspati took her back without punishment. The child born of this union was Budh - Planet Mercury in Vedic tradition, worshipped today as part of the Navagrahas. And it is from Chandra himself - at the centre of this episode of divine complexity - that the ChandraVansh takes its name and origin, eventually birthing Lord Krishna.

Our tradition did not erase this complex history. It named a prestigious dynasty after it.

These stories that our priests recite and grandmothers remember are unanimous on this: a person is not their history. The comments on social media said otherwise. Our tradition did not.

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SAIL conducts Leadership Workshop on Digital Transformation

PNS : RANCHI

Steel Authority of India Limited organised a two-day immersive workshop on Digital Transformation for its senior leadership under the "Pravartanam" leadership activation initiative at Management Training Institute Ranchi on May 25 and 26, 2026.

The programme brought together 32 Executive Directors and Chief General Managers of SAIL with the objective of enhancing leadership awareness, appreciation, and readiness for driving digital transformation across the organisation. The workshop focused on emerging technologies and their applications in the steel sector, including Artificial Intelligence (AI), Machine Learning (ML), Generative AI, Agentic AI, and various digital use cases currently being implemented across SAIL operations. Special hands-on sessions were also conducted to help participants understand how digital technologies can simplify daily work processes and improve decision-making. The programme was inaugurated by SAIL's Director (Personnel), who highlighted the growing importance of proactively embracing digital transformation to ensure organisations remain future-ready and globally competitive. Executive Director (Digital Transformation) and Executive Director (HR-L&D) also underlined the company's commitment to building digitally empowered leadership and accelerating organisational transformation towards sustainability and profitability.



ICAR-IIAB inks MoU with king fisheries to promote sustainable aquaculture in Jharkhand

PNS : RANCHI

ICAR-Indian Institute of Agricultural Biotechnology (ICAR-IIAB), Ranchi signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with King Fisheries, Ratu, Ranchi on May 29, 2026 to strengthen collaborative efforts in sustainable aquaculture, fisheries innovation, research, training and livelihood development in Jharkhand.

The MoU was signed by Dr. Sujay Rakshit, Director, ICAR-IIAB, Ranchi and representatives of King Fisheries in the presence of officials from both organizations. The collaboration aims to promote scientific fish breeding, hatchery management, fish health and nutrition, integrated aquaculture systems, ornamental fisheries, nanotechnology applications in fisheries, and climate-resilient aquaculture practices.

Under the partnership,



both organizations will jointly organize farmer training programmes, demonstrations, exposure visits, workshops and entrepreneurship development activities for fish farmers, tribal youth, women self-help groups and rural entrepreneurs. The collaboration will also facilitate student internships, field-based research, technology validation and dissemination of improved aquaculture technologies.

Speaking on the occasion, Dr. Sujay Rakshit emphasized the importance of scientific

interventions and institutional partnerships for enhancing fish production, strengthening rural livelihoods and developing Jharkhand as a model state for sustainable fisheries and aquaculture development.

The MoU is expected to create new opportunities for research, innovation, skill development and entrepreneurship in the fisheries sector while contributing towards livelihood enhancement and socio-economic development of rural communities.

Multiple express trains delayed at Tatanagar, passengers stranded

PNS : JAMSHEDPUR

Railway passengers at Tatanagar Station faced severe inconvenience on Friday as several major express trains arriving from the Mumbai-Bilaspur route ran heavily behind schedule, leaving hundreds stranded on overcrowded platforms for hours.

Despite repeated assurances from senior railway officials regarding improved punctuality and operational efficiency under the Tatanagar and Chakradharpur railway divisions, delays continue to disrupt passenger movement across key routes.

Among the major long-distance trains affected were the Ahmedabad Express, Gitanjali Express, Kurla Express, and Mumbai Mail.

The delays triggered frus-



tration among families, office-goers, business travelers, and daily commuters who were forced to wait amid uncertainty and repeated schedule revisions.

Railway officials and technical staff familiar with operations stated that the delays were largely inherited from originating and intermediate stations rather than being caused within the local division.

According to them, trains entering the Chakradharpur division through the busy Mumbai-Howrah corridor are already running late, making it extremely difficult for local authorities to recover lost time and restore schedules. The disruption was not limited to Tatanagar alone. Several regional routes also witnessed major delays, exposing wider scheduling

and operational strain across the railway network. The Itwari Express and Kantabanji-Howrah Steel Express reportedly ran over six hours late, while the Junagarh-Howrah Ispat Express was delayed by nearly 12 hours despite recent reviews and assurances by the General Manager regarding structural improvements in train operations.

Rail connectivity towards Bihar also remained severely affected, with reports indicating that more than 15 trains reaching Muzaffarpur were delayed by up to 10 hours. Passengers have once again demanded stronger coordination between railway divisions and stricter monitoring of train movement to improve punctuality on one of the country's busiest railway corridors.

